

No Blueprint Included: Freedom and Anxiety in Existentialist Philosophy

An original lesson plan inspired by **Kevin Aho's** the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Existentialism. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Kevin Aho. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/existentialism/>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Existentialism

“If there is no pre-given human nature or blueprint dictating who you should become, then you are radically free to define yourself through your own choices — is that freedom liberating, terrifying, or both at once?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Identify the core commitments shared across existentialist philosophy despite its diverse figures: the primacy of lived, subjective experience, the claim that 'existence precedes essence,' and the distinction between authentic and inauthentic living.
- Compare how at least two existentialist thinkers (for example, Kierkegaard and Sartre, or Heidegger and Sartre) treat anxiety or anguish as a revealing, rather than merely negative, experience.
- Apply the concept of inauthenticity/bad faith to identify examples in contemporary life, and construct an argument about what living authentically would require instead.

Materials Needed

- Quote handout with short representative passages from Kierkegaard, Heidegger, and Sartre on anxiety, facticity, and authenticity
- Comparison chart (one column per thinker) for the station activity
- Whiteboard for the opening exercise
- Scenario cards depicting everyday situations for the closing bad-faith activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Design-a-Human

8 min

Ask students to imagine a factory that manufactures toasters: the toaster's purpose (its essence) is decided before a single unit is built. Ask: is a human being like that — built to a pre-existing purpose or nature — or not? Collect initial reactions on the board without resolving the question yet; this previews 'existence precedes essence.'

Direct Instruction: Existence Precedes Essence

17 min

Introduce the existentialist slogan that for human beings, existence precedes essence: we simply find ourselves existing first, with no fixed nature determining in advance who we are, and only afterward do we define ourselves through our choices and actions. Connect this to the shared existentialist emphasis on lived, first-person experience over abstract theorizing about human nature, and introduce authenticity (owning your choices as genuinely yours) versus inauthenticity (drifting along on others' expectations or excuses) as the central practical stakes of this claim.

Small-Group Station Analysis

18 min

Set up three stations, one per thinker (Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Sartre), each with a short quote on anxiety or anguish. Groups rotate through all three, filling in the comparison chart: what triggers anxiety for this thinker, and what does anxiety reveal about the human condition (for Kierkegaard, the 'dizziness of freedom' before an unmade choice; for Heidegger, our being thrown into a world we didn't choose yet must still take up as our own; for Sartre, that we are 'condemned to be free' with no excuse available for what we become).

Whole-Class Bad Faith Sorting

12 min

Present 4-5 scenario cards depicting people avoiding responsibility for a choice (blaming 'that's just who I am,' following a role unreflectively, claiming 'I had no choice'). As a class, sort each into bad faith/inauthentic versus a genuine, owned choice, and discuss what a more authentic response would look like in each case.

Closure

5 min

Return to the hook. Ask students whether they've changed their answer about whether humans are like toasters, and to state in one sentence what 'existence precedes essence' would mean for how they think about their own future.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If there really is no pre-given human nature, does that mean literally any way of living is as legitimate as any other, or does existentialism still leave room to call some choices better or worse than others?
- 2 Kierkegaard, Heidegger, and Sartre all treat anxiety as revealing something true about the human condition rather than as a problem to be cured — do you find that framing convincing, or does it romanticize what is really just discomfort?
- 3 Is it possible to live entirely without any 'bad faith,' fully owning every choice you make, or is some degree of inauthenticity an unavoidable part of functioning in society?

- 4 If you are 'condemned to be free,' as Sartre claims, does that make you responsible even for things that feel like they happened to you, such as your emotional reactions or your circumstances of birth?
- 5 Existentialism emphasizes individual, lived experience over abstract theory — but doesn't the very act of writing philosophical treatises about existentialism risk turning it into exactly the kind of abstract theory it claims to reject?

Assessment

Students write a short response identifying one scenario from their own life (real or plausible) in which they recognize a pattern of inauthenticity/bad faith, explaining using specific vocabulary from at least two thinkers covered in class (facticity, anxiety, thrownness, bad faith) what a more authentic response would have looked like.

Extension Activity

Have students choose a character from a book, film, or show and write a short analysis of a key decision that character makes, evaluating it as authentic or inauthentic using the existentialist vocabulary from class, with specific attention to whether the character is owning their freedom or evading it.

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